was delayed by several years. It was not until 15 February 1931 that the new grand capital of British India was officially inaugurated.

1912 was also a year of change in Japan. On 30 July, the Meiji Emperor died. He had ascended the throne in 1867 and his reign had seen the transformation of Japan from a feudal society to an industrialized world power. His funeral was described by the *Japan Advertiser* on 17 September as ‘a fairy tale of lights’ with old-fashioned ‘frock-coated and silk-hatted gentlemen’, and sacred oxen in front of the funeral car, and ‘hundreds of men in peaked hats and gold laced uniforms’ from the navy and army behind. ‘The contrast between that which preceded the funeral car and that which followed it was striking indeed. Before it went old Japan; after it came new Japan,’ the newspaper reported.[2]

The powerful Meiji Emperor was succeeded by his son Yoshihito, who assumed the imperial name Taisho. In sharp contrast to his father, the Taisho Emperor was weak and suffered from various neurological ailments, making it impossible for him to carry out his duties. Real power shifted to a group of older statesmen who ran the country without much interference from the emperor. Taisho’s reign, from 1912 to his death in 1926, has therefore become known as the ‘Taisho democracy’. There was room for political manoeuvre outside the imperial palace, but it did not amount to democracy in the western sense.

During World War I, Japan sided with the Allied powers, declared war on Germany, occupying the former German colonies in the Asia-Pacific, Qingdao on the Chinese coast, and the Carolines, the Marianas, and the Marshall Islands in the Pacific. Qingdao had to be returned to China in 1922, but, taking advantage of the weakened Republic, the Japanese expanded their influence over other parts of the Chinese mainland and adjoining areas. The Korean peninsula had already been annexed in 1910, now Japan took over German commercial holdings in Manchuria and Inner Mongolia.

When the Taisho Emperor died at the age of 47 in 1926, he was succeeded by his eldest son Hirohito, who became the Showa Emperor. Under Taisho’s rather weak reign, the Japanese military had become the most powerful force in the country—and that would lead to more wars with China in the 1930s and 1940s. Japan was emerging as a military and political superpower in Asia.